LOOKING CLOSER

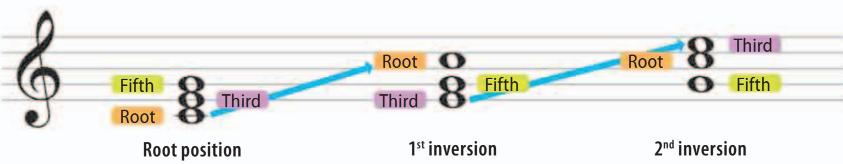
Rules for interval inversion

General rules help you to remember the inversions of intervals. The number of half steps always adds up to 12—the number of half steps in an octave.

- Perfect intervals remain perfect
- Augmented intervals become diminished
- Major intervals become minor
- Diminished intervals become augmented
- Minor intervals become major
- A tritone remains a tritone

Chord inversions

Inverting a diatonic chord means starting it on another note of the triad of the key signature on which it is based. The first inversion starts the chord on the third, and the second inversion starts the chord on the fifth. A third inversion would bring the tonic back to root position, so the term is redundant.



◁ **Inverting a C major triad**
The notes are the same, C-E-G, but the pitch will vary according to the inversions.

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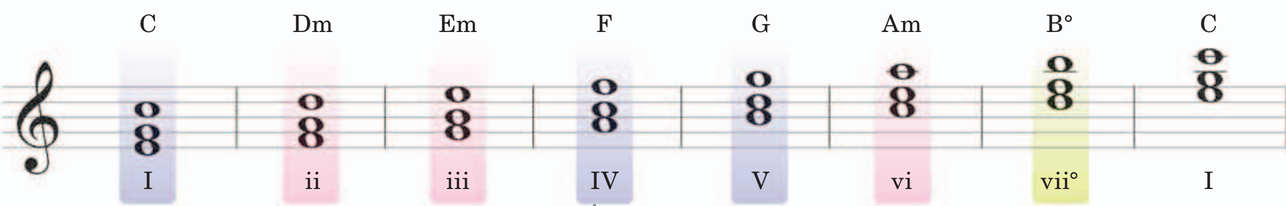
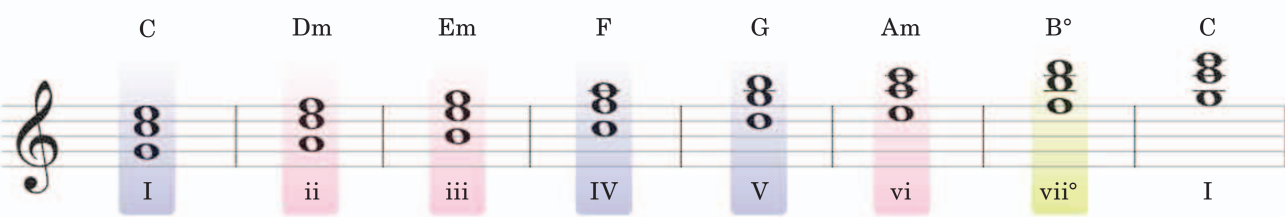


The C is at the top of the chord, while E and G retain their positions.

F is the subdominant (IV) of C, so this note appears at the top.

This is known as a G6 chord, because the interval between B and G is a sixth. Within the context of C major, it is a V6, because the root is the dominant or fifth.

△ **First inversions**
As with their root positions, the C, F, and G chords are major, the D, E, and A chords are minor, and the B chord is diminished. The bottom note of the scale has moved to the top, so that the lowest note is the third of the original triad.



Just as first inversion chords have a 6 after their letter, this is known as a 6/4 chord, because G-C is a perfect fourth, and G-E is a major sixth.

C is the bottom note, because in an F chord, C is the dominant.

△ **Second inversions**
The second inversion builds a chord from the fifth (dominant) of the tonic triad. The original root is now the middle note of the triad, and the original third is on top.